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PRIMED FOR ACTION
Prime Minister Narendra Modi with defence minister Rajnath Singh, NSA Ajit Doval, CDS Gen Anil Chauhan and the three service chiefs at a meeting in New Delhi, April 29

TO DETER ANY FUTURE MISADVENTURE, INDIA HAS MADE IT CLEAR THAT PAKISTAN WILL HAVE TO PAY A HEAVY PRICE AND BE PREPARED FOR A WAR WITH INDIA

Strategists outline another reason for Munir to strike now—the perception that India was running away with the ball on Kashmir. With Article 370 abrogated, an elected government in place, and the return of tourists to the Valley, there was a fear that the situation in Kashmir would turn irrevocably in New Delhi's favour. Hence a Mumbai 2008 kind of attack on civilians became necessary to blow the illusion of peace and stability in the Valley. Experts also see the Pahalgam attacks as part of a concerted plan by the ISI to launch what is known as the K2 operation—unleash both Kashmir and Khalistan terrorists to destabilise the two frontier states. The terrorists in Kashmir are well-trained and equipped with the latest weapons. They are also using sophisticated communication technology, of Chinese origin perhaps, which India has found difficult to intercept and decrypt. With better command, control and coordination with each other, they first struck the Jammu region last year just before the assembly election in October, and have subsequently targeted the Valley. In Punjab, terrorists are pushing heavy amounts of drugs and also encouraging gang wars to unleash mayhem in the state.

Drumming Up International Support

Kugelman points out how Munir has been preparing the ground for international support for the jihad he is waging against India. When Donald Trump took over as US President, he cosied up to him by getting ISIS-K commander Mohammad Sharifullah, who was hiding in Pakistan, arrested and deported to the US. Sharifullah had plotted the deadly Abbey Gate bombing that killed 13 US service members while they were being evacuated from Afghanistan. Trump thanked Pakistan for helping the US out. Just a week before the arrest was made public, the US had released $397 million to Pakistan for the maintenance of its F-16s. After Pahalgam, Trump condemned the terror attack, but did not blame Pakistan. He maintained that the conflict with India was "on for thousands of years" and the two countries should sort it out together. China and Turkey were anyway toeing the Pakistani line for an independent investigation into the terror attack. Over the past two years, Pakistan has been purchasing state-of-the-art military equipment from both these countries, in addition to sophisticated electronic warfare items from China. Despite his country's financial crunch, Munir embarked on a modernisation programme of the army that now seems to have given him the confidence to take on India.

But Munir may just have overreached with his most recent provocation. Targeting tourists in Pahalgam has damaged Pakistan's prospects in Kashmir because, for the first time, the Valley has risen unitedly in protest and condemned the attacks. These directly impacted tourism, which had been booming for the past two years, affecting their livelihood. Experts in Pakistan are despairing over Munir's actions, saying a military conflict with India is the last thing the country can afford, especially as it has far from recovered from the economic crisis. They believe Munir's ISI past has made him reckless, pointing out that rarely does someone who heads the spy agency become the chief. As one expert put it, "When it comes to lighting fires, Munir may have been very good. But the Pakistan army has historically understood that if you let somebody with the matchbox be in charge, then you need to keep an eye on them to avoid a conflagration."

With no one capable of restraining Munir in Pakistan, it falls on the Modi government to punish the errant general. As Bisaria says, "Pakistan knows it will have a heavy cost to pay and must be prepared for war with India. That is the only deterrent to prevent such misadventures in future." ■